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Habakkuk - Introduction

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Part 1: General Introduction

Outline of Habakkuk

1. Superscription
2. Habakkuk's first complaint: Why does Yahweh tolerate injustice in Judah?
3. Yahweh's first reply: He is raising up the Chaldeans as his instrument of judgment
4. Habakkuk's second complaint: Why does Yahweh use a nation more wicked than Judah?
5. Habakkuk waits for Yahweh's answer
6. Yahweh's second reply: The vision is certain; the righteous shall live by faith
7. Five woe oracles against the oppressor

- Woe to the one who increases what is not his
- Woe to the one who gains evil gain for his house
- Woe to the one who builds a city with bloodshed
- Woe to the one who makes his neighbor drink
- Woe to the one who says to wood, "Awake!"

1. Habakkuk's prayer-psalm: a theophany and confession of trust

- Superscription
- Petition for Yahweh to act again
- Theophany: Yahweh appears as a divine warrior
- Habakkuk's response: from trembling to trust
- Liturgical colophon

What is the book of Habakkuk about?
Unlike most prophetic books, Habakkuk is not primarily a message from God to the people. Instead, it is a dialogue between the prophet and Yahweh. Habakkuk complains that Yahweh is allowing injustice and violence to go unchecked in Judah, and Yahweh responds that he is raising up the Chaldeans (the Babylonians) to punish Judah. This answer disturbs Habakkuk even more, and he asks why Yahweh would use a nation more wicked than Judah to carry out judgment. Yahweh's second reply assures the prophet that the oppressor will also be judged in due time and that the righteous will live by faithfulness. The book concludes with a powerful prayer-psalm in which Habakkuk recounts Yahweh's mighty acts in the past and resolves to trust him even when all visible sources of provision fail.

The book moves from protest to praise, from questioning God's justice to affirming trust in God's character. This makes it a distinctive resource for communities that are experiencing suffering and questioning why God permits injustice.

Who wrote the book of Habakkuk?
The book identifies Habakkuk as a prophet, but it tells us nothing else about his background. The liturgical notations in chapter 3, including the superscription "on shigyonoth" and the colophon "to the chief musician, on my stringed instruments," suggest that Habakkuk may have been associated with the temple worship in Jerusalem. Most scholars date the book to the late seventh century B.C., shortly before the Babylonian invasion of Judah (605–586 B.C.), since Habakkuk speaks of the Chaldean rise as something Yahweh is about to do.

How should the title of this book be translated?
Translators may use the traditional title "The Book of Habakkuk" or simply "Habakkuk." They may also use a title such as "The Prophecy of Habakkuk" or "The Prophecies of Habakkuk."

Part 2: Important Religious and Cultural Concepts

The "burden" or oracle
The book opens with the Hebrew word translated "burden," which also means a prophetic oracle or message. This term is used in several prophetic books to introduce a weighty message from Yahweh. Translators may need to use a word such as "message" or "prophecy" rather than a word for a physical load, unless their language has a similar dual meaning.

The righteous shall live by faith
In 2:4, Yahweh contrasts the proud person, whose soul is not upright, with the righteous person, who shall live by his faithfulness. The Hebrew word can mean both "faithfulness" (loyal trust in Yahweh) and "faith" (belief in Yahweh's promises). This verse is quoted three times in the New Testament (Romans 1:17; Galatians 3:11; Hebrews 10:38) and became central to the Protestant Reformation. Translators should be aware that their rendering of this verse will be compared with the New Testament quotations.

Theodicy: questioning God's justice
Habakkuk is one of the few biblical books that directly questions why Yahweh permits evil. The prophet does not doubt Yahweh's existence or power; he struggles to reconcile Yahweh's holiness with the presence of

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injustice. This theme connects Habakkuk with the book of Job and certain psalms of lament. In some cultures, it may be unusual for a person to question God openly. Translators should be aware that the text presents this questioning as an act of faith rather than rebellion.

The Chaldeans
The Chaldeans were the people group that established the Neo-Babylonian Empire, which conquered Judah and destroyed the temple in Jerusalem in 586 B.C. Yahweh describes them as "bitter and hasty" and characterizes their military power with vivid comparisons to leopards, wolves, and eagles. Translators may wish to include a footnote explaining that "Chaldeans" refers to the Babylonians.

Theophany
Chapter 3 describes Yahweh appearing as a divine warrior who shakes the earth, splits rivers, and commands the heavens. This kind of description, in which God appears with cosmic power, is called a theophany. It draws on the tradition of Yahweh's mighty acts at the exodus and the conquest of the promised land. Translators should present these descriptions as poetic imagery of God's power rather than as literal descriptions of a past or future event.

Part 3: Important Translation Issues

Dialogue structure
The book alternates between the prophet's words and Yahweh's words, but it does not always mark the transitions with explicit speaker labels. In chapter 1, the shifts occur at verses 2, 5, and 12. In chapter 2, Habakkuk speaks in verse 1, and Yahweh speaks from verse 2 onward. Translators may wish to use section headings, paragraph breaks, or other formatting to help readers follow the dialogue. Notes in the individual chapters will identify the speaker at each transition.

Hebrew poetry: parallelism
The book of Habakkuk is written almost entirely in poetry. Hebrew poetry was based on repetition of meaning rather than on repetition of sound. A speaker would typically say one phrase and then say another phrase that meant a similar thing, an opposite thing, or something supplementary. This second phrase would advance the meaning of the first phrase in some way. In many cases it would be good to show this to readers by including all the phrases in the translation rather than combining them. However, if the repetition might be confusing, translators could connect the phrases with a word that shows how the second phrase advances the meaning of the first one. Notes throughout the book will model ways of doing this in various cases.

Woe oracles
Chapter 2 contains five pronouncements that begin with the word "Woe" (verses 6, 9, 12, 15, 19). This word communicates a warning about coming disaster for the person described. If the word "woe" does not communicate this meaning in a target language, translators could use an equivalent expression such as "How terrible it will be for" or "Disaster will come upon."

Difficult Hebrew in 1:9 and 3:9
Some verses in Habakkuk contain Hebrew words and phrases whose meaning is debated among scholars. In 1:9, the phrase about the direction of the Chaldeans' faces is uncertain, and in 3:9, the line about oaths and staffs is one of the most difficult lines in the Hebrew Bible. The ULT provides a literal rendering in these cases, and the UST offers a meaning-based interpretation. Notes at these places will alert translators to the difficulty and suggest possible readings.

Selah
The word "Selah" appears three times in chapter 3 (verses 3, 9, 13). This term is found almost exclusively in the Psalms and in Habakkuk 3. Its exact meaning is uncertain, but it likely indicates a musical or liturgical pause. Translators may choose to keep the word "Selah" as a loanword or to translate it with a term meaning "pause" or "musical interlude."

Figurative language for military power
Throughout the book, both Yahweh and Habakkuk use vivid figurative language to describe the Chaldean military: horses swifter than leopards, fiercer than evening wolves, horsemen that fly like eagles; a fisherman catching people with hooks, nets, and dragnets; and a person making his neighbor drink to expose his nakedness. Translators should preserve these figures of speech where possible and provide alternate translations in cases where the images would not be understood in the target culture. Notes will address each of these images individually.

Habakkuk - Chapter 1 Introduction

Structure and Formatting
This chapter is a prophetic lament dialogue: the prophet complains about injustice, Yahweh announces the Chaldean invasion, then the prophet protests again. See: lament, lamentation

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

The Oracle (Burden)
The Hebrew word for "burden" also means a prophetic oracle. Translators may need to use "message" or "oracle" rather than implying a physical load.

Justice
Habakkuk protests that justice has collapsed in Judah, then questions why Yahweh uses an even more wicked nation to punish them.

Habakkuk 1:1 (#1)

הַמַּשָּׂאָ֣ א אֲשֶׁ֣ ר חָזָ֔ ה חֲבַקּ֖ וּק הַנָּבִֽ יא

"The oracle that Habakkuk the prophet saw"

Here the author is providing background information to help readers understand what happens next in the story. In your translation, introduce this information in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture.

See: Background Information

Habakkuk 1:1 (#2)

הַמַּשָּׂאָ֣ א

"The oracle"

Here, **oracle** represents a prophetic message. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [The prophetic message that Habakkuk the prophet received]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk 1:2 (#1)

עַד־אָ֥ נָה יְהוָ֖ ה שִׁוַּ֣ עְתִּי וְלֹ֥ א תִשְׁמָ֖ ע

"Until when, Yahweh, will I cry aloud, but you will not listen"

Habakkuk is using the question form to express his frustration and lament to Yahweh. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, I have cried aloud for so long, but you will not listen!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Habakkuk 1:2 (#2)

חָמָ֑ ס

"Violence"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **Violence**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [People are acting violently]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 1:3 (#1)

לָ֣ מָּה תַרְאֵ֤ נִי אָ֙ וֶן֙ וְעָמָ֣ ל תַּבִּ֔ יט

"Why do you make me see iniquity, and {why} do you behold trouble"

Habakkuk is using the question form to express his protest against what Yahweh is allowing to happen. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You make me see iniquity and you behold trouble!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Habakkuk 1:3 (#2)

אָ֙ וֶן֙

"iniquity"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [people doing wrong]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 1:3 (#3)

וְשֹׁ֥ ד וְחָמָ֖ ס

"And destruction and violence {are"

The terms **destruction** and **violence** mean similar things. Habakkuk is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [And brutal devastation is]

See: Doublet

Habakkuk 1:3 (#4)

וְשֹׁ֥ ד וְחָמָ֖ ס & וַיְהִ֥ י רִ֖ יב

"And destruction and violence {are & and {there} is strife"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **destruction**, **violence**, or **strife**, you could express the same ideas in another way. Alternate translation: [And people ruining things and people acting violently are ... and there are people quarreling]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 1:4 (#1)

עַל־כֵּ֤ן תָּפ֙וּג תּוֹרָ֔ה וְלֹא־יֵצֵ֥א לָנֶ֖צַח מִשְׁפָּ֑ט

“Therefore the law weakens, and justice does not go forth to perpetuity”

These two clauses mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in the Psalms, and follow that approach here and throughout this psalm. Alternate translation: [Therefore the law is powerless because no one upholds justice]

See: Parallelism

Habakkuk 1:4 (#2)

עַל־כֵּ֤ן תָּפ֙וּג תּוֹרָ֔ה

“Therefore the law weakens”

Here, **Therefore** indicates that what follows is the result of the injustice Habakkuk has just described. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different connecting word to express a result. Alternate translation: [As a result, the law weakens]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Habakkuk 1:4 (#3)

תָּפ֙וּג תּוֹרָ֔ה

“the law weakens”

Habakkuk is speaking of **the law** as if it were a person who could become physically weak. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the law has no power]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 1:4 (#4)

וְלֹא־יֵצֵ֥א לָנֶ֖צַח מִשְׁפָּ֑ט

“and justice does not go forth to perpetuity”

Habakkuk is speaking of **justice** as if it were a person who could go out and act. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and judges do not make fair decisions]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 1:4 (#5)

מִשְׁפָּ֑ט

“justice”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **justice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a fair decision]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 1:4 (#6)

רָשָׁ֣ע

“the wicked”

Habakkuk is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to refer to a kind of person. If your language does not use adjectives as nouns, you could translate this with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the wicked person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Habakkuk 1:4 (#7)

אֶת־הַצַּדִּ֔יק

“the righteous”

Habakkuk is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to refer to a kind of person. If your language does not use adjectives as nouns, you could translate this with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the righteous person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Habakkuk 1:5 (#1)

רְא֤וּ בַגּוֹיִם֙ וְהַבִּ֣יטוּ וְהִתַּמְּהוּ֔

“See among the nations and consider, and be amazed”

Here Yahweh begins to respond to Habakkuk’s complaint. In your translation, introduce this new event in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture. See the UST for an example.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Habakkuk 1:5 (#2)

רְא֤וּ בַגּוֹיִם֙ וְהַבִּ֣יטוּ וְהִתַּמְּהוּ֔ תְּמָהּ֖וּ

“See among the nations and consider, and be amazed, be amazed”

Yahweh is using these imperatives to command his audience to pay attention to what he is about to reveal. If a speaker of your language would not use commands in this way, you could translate these commands using another form that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [You should look among the nations and pay attention, and you will be amazed and astonished!]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Habakkuk 1:5 (#3)

וְהֵתַמְהוּ תְּמָהוּ

“and be amazed, be amazed”

Yahweh is the phrase **be amazed** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [and be utterly astonished!]

See: Reduplication

Habakkuk 1:5 (#4)

פֹּעֵל֙ פֹּעֵ֣ל

“I am working a work”

The phrase **working a work** uses the same Hebrew root for both the verb and its object. This emphasizes the greatness or significance of the action. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [I am doing a mighty deed]

See: Poetry

Habakkuk 1:6 (#1)

כִּי־הִנְנֵ֣י מֵקִ֔ים אֶת־הַכַּשְׂדִּ֔ים

“For behold me, raising up the Chaldeans”

The expression **behold me** was a common way of introducing a divine announcement. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [For pay attention, I am raising up the Chaldeans]

See: Idiom

Habakkuk 1:6 (#2)

לֹא־לֹ֑ו

“not to him”

Here, **to him** refers to the Chaldean nation. Yahweh is describing the nation in the third person using a singular pronoun. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the referent plainly. Alternate translation: [not belonging to them]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Habakkuk 1:6 (#3)

הַגּוֹי֙ הַמַּ֣ר וְהַנִּמְהָ֔ר

“the bitter and hastening nation”

Yahweh is speaking of the Chaldean nation as if it were a person with the emotional qualities of being **bitter** and hasty. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a nation whose warriors are terrible and fast]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 1:7 (#1)

וּשְׂאֵתֹ֖ו

“and his dignity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **dignity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and his worthiness of respect]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 1:7 (#2)

אֵ֣ימ וְנֹורָ֔א הֵ֖מָּה מִמֶּ֣נּוּ מִשְׁפָּטֹ֑ו וּשְׂאֵתֹ֖ו יֵצֵֽא

“He {is} dreadful and terrifying; from him goes forth his justice and his dignity”

The pronouns **He, him,** and **his** in this verse continue to refer to the Chaldean nation. See how Yahweh introduced this nation in the previous verse. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the referent plainly. Alternate translation: [That nation is dreadful and terrifying; from it goes forth its own justice and its own dignity]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Habakkuk 1:8 (#1)

וּפָ֨שׁוּ פָרָשָׁ֜יו וּפָרָשָׁ֗יו מֵרָחֹ֤וק יָבֹ֙אוּ֙

“And his horsemen spread out, and his horsemen come from a distance”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of clauses in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [And his horsemen advance rapidly from far away]

See: Parallelism

Habakkuk 1:8 (#2)

יָעֻפּוּ כְנֶשֶׁר חָחֵשׁ לֶאֱכוֹל

“they fly like an eagle rushing to devour”

Yahweh is comparing the Chaldean attack to **an eagle rushing to devour** its prey. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this comparison in another way. Alternate translation: [they attack as swiftly as an eagle diving for prey]

See: Simile

Habakkuk 1:9 (#1)

מְגַמַּת פְּנֵיהֶם קָדִימָה

“The direction of their faces {is} eastward”

The phrase **The direction of their faces {is} eastward** is a translation of the written Hebrew text. This reading, however, is only one of several possibilities suggested by scholars. Scholars have proposed some alternative readings, and you may want to follow one of those. The UST follows the first alternative. Alternate translation: [Everyone is terrified as they approach] or [The set of their faces is like the east wind]

See: Alternative Readings

Habakkuk 1:9 (#2)

מְגַמַּת פְּנֵיהֶם קָדִימָה

“The direction of their faces {is} eastward”

Here, **faces** represents the determined direction of the Chaldean advance. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [They all press forward toward the east]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk 1:9 (#3)

וַיֶּאֱסֹף & שֶׁבִי

“and he gathers captives”

Here the singular pronoun **he** refers to the Chaldean nation collectively. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural pronoun. Alternate translation: [and they gather captives]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Habakkuk 1:9 (#4)

וַיֶּאֱסֹף כַּחחָוֹל שֶׁבִי

“and he gathers captives like the sand”

Yahweh says that the Chaldean gathers captives **like the sand** as an extreme statement to emphasize the vast number of people captured. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [and he gathers more captives than anyone can count]

See: Hyperbole

Habakkuk 1:10 (#1)

וְהוּא בַּמְּלָכִים יִתְקַלָּס וְרוֹזְנִים מִשְׂחָק לוֹ

“And he, he mocks at kings, and rulers {are} laughter to him”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of clauses in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [And he thoroughly ridicules all rulers and kings]

See: Parallelism

Habakkuk 1:10 (#2)

וְהוּא בַּמְּלָכִים יִתְקַלָּס

“And he, he mocks at kings”

Here, the author uses the independent pronoun **he** twice for emphasis in the Hebrew. If a speaker of your language would not repeat the pronoun, you could express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [And he himself mocks at kings]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Habakkuk 1:10 (#3)

וְרוֹזְנִים מִשְׂחָק לוֹ

“and rulers {are} laughter to him”

The author is speaking of **rulers** as if they were merely objects of his **laughter**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he laughs at rulers]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 1:10 (#4)

מִשְׂחָק

“are} laughter”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **laughter**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [are something he laughs at]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 1:10 (#5)

וַיִּצְבֹּר עָפָר וַיִּלְכְּדָהּ

“for he piles up dirt and captures it”

In this verse, the mocking of kings and rulers is described before the military action that makes that mocking possible. He piles up a siege ramp and captures the fortress—and that is why he can mock. If your language needs an explicit connector to show that the second clause is the result of the first, you could use one. Alternate translation: [He piles up dirt and captures every fortress, and so he mocks at kings, and rulers are laughter to him.]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Habakkuk 1:10 (#6)

הוּא לְכָל־מִבְצָר יִשְׂחָק

“He, he laughs at every fortress”

Here the author again uses the independent pronoun **He** twice for emphasis in the Hebrew. If a speaker of your language would not repeat the pronoun, you could express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [He himself laughs at every fortress]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Habakkuk 1:11 (#1)

אָז חָלַף רוּחַ וַיַּעֲבֹר

“Then he sweeps by {like} the wind and goes on”

The word **Then** indicates that this event happens after the events previously described. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different connecting word to express a sequential relationship. Alternate translation: [After that, he sweeps by like the wind and goes on]

See: Connect — Sequential Time Relationship

Habakkuk 1:11 (#2)

אָז חָלַף רוּחַ וַיַּעֲבֹר

“Then he sweeps by {like} the wind and goes on”

Yahweh is comparing the Chaldean’s advance to **the wind** to describe how quickly and unstoppably he passes through. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this comparison in another way. Alternate translation: [Then he passes through swiftly and goes on]

See: Simile

Habakkuk 1:11 (#3)

זֶה כֹּחוֹ לֵאלֹהָיו

“this {one} whose might {is} his god”

The author is speaking of military **might** as if it were a **god** that the Chaldean worships. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [this one who treats his own strength as his deity]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 1:11 (#4)

כֹּחוֹ

“whose might”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **might**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [whose strength in battle]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 1:12 (#1)

הֲלֹוא אַתָּה מִקֶּדֶם יְהוָה אֱלֹהַי קְדֹשִׁי

“Are} you not from ancient times, Yahweh my God, my Holy One”

Habakkuk is using the question form to affirm that Yahweh has existed from ancient times. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You have existed from ancient times, Yahweh my God, my Holy One.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Habakkuk 1:12 (#2)

יְהוָה אֱלֹהַי קְדֹשִׁי

“Yahweh my God, my Holy One”

The terms **Yahweh my God** and **my Holy One** mean similar things. The writer is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, my holy God]

See: Doublet

Habakkuk 1:12 (#3)

לְמִשְׁפָּט

“for judgment”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgment**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for judging us]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 1:12 (#4)

וְצוּר

“and Rock”

Habakkuk is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a **Rock**, to emphasize his stability and reliability. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and our firm foundation]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 1:12 (#5)

הֲלֹוא אַתָּה מִקֶּדֶם

“Are} you not from ancient times”

Here Habakkuk begins a second complaint to Yahweh, preparing to question why Yahweh would use the Chaldeans to punish Judah. In your translation, introduce this new event in a way that would be natural in your own language and culture. Alternate translation: [Have you not been from long ago]

See: Introduction of a New Event

Habakkuk 1:13 (#1)

טְהֹר עֵינַיִם מֵרְאֹות רָע

“Your eyes are pure from seeing evil”

Here, **Your eyes** represents Yahweh’s ability to perceive and attend to things. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [You are too pure to look at evil]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk 1:13 (#2)

טְהֹר עֵינַיִם מֵרְאֹות רָע וְהַבִּיט אֶל־עָמָל לֹא תוּכָל

“Your eyes are pure from seeing evil, and you are not able to look at trouble”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of clauses in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [You are completely unable to look upon evil or trouble]

See: Parallelism

Habakkuk 1:13 (#3)

לָמָּה תַבִּיט בּוֹגְדִים תַּחֲרִישׁ בְּבַלַּע רָשָׁע צַדִּיק מִמֶּנּוּ

“Why do you look at treacherous ones, keep silent when the wicked devours {one} more righteous than him”

Habakkuk is using the question form to express his protest against Yahweh’s apparent tolerance of treachery. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You should not look at treacherous ones or keep silent when the wicked devours one more righteous than him!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Habakkuk 1:13 (#4)

רָשָׁע

“the wicked”

Habakkuk is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to refer to a kind of person. If your language does not use adjectives as nouns, you could translate this with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the wicked person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Habakkuk 1:14 (#1)

וַתַּעֲשֶׂה אָדָם כִּדְגֵי הַיָּם

“And you make man like the fish of the sea”

Habakkuk is comparing helpless humans to **the fish of the sea**, which can be caught without resistance. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this comparison in another way. Alternate translation: [And you make man as helpless as the fish of the sea]

See: Simile

Habakkuk 1:14 (#2)

כָּרֶמֶשׂ לֹא־מֹשֵׁל בּוֹ

“like a creeping thing {with} no ruler over it”

Habakkuk is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Al-

ternate translation: [and you make man like a creeping thing with no ruler over it]

See: Ellipsis

Habakkuk 1:14 (#3)

כְּרֶמֶשׂ לֹא־מֹשֵׁל בּוֹ

“like a creeping thing {with} no ruler over it”

Habakkuk is comparing humans to **a creeping thing** that has no one to protect or lead it. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this comparison in another way. Alternate translation: [like creatures that have no one to protect them]

See: Simile

Habakkuk 1:15 (#1)

כֻּלּוֹ בְּחַכָּה הֶעֱלָה

“All of them, he brings up with a hook”

Habakkuk is speaking of the Chaldean conquest as if the Chaldean were a fisherman pulling people up with **a hook**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [All of them, he captures easily]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 1:15 (#2)

יְגֹרֲרֵהוּ בְחֶרְמֹו וְיַאַסְפֵֻהוּ בְּמִכְמַרְתֹּו

“He drags him with his net, and he gathers him with his dragnet”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of clauses in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [He catches him easily in his net] or [He drags him with his net; indeed, he gathers him with his dragnet]

See: Parallelism

Habakkuk 1:15 (#3)

יְגֹרֲרֵהוּ בְחֶרְמֹו וְיַאַסְפֵֻהוּ בְּמִכְמַרְתֹּו

“He drags him with his net, and he gathers him with his dragnet”

Habakkuk is speaking of the Chaldean conquest as if the Chaldean were a fisherman catching people with **his net** and **his dragnet**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He captures people with his army, and he sweeps them up in large numbers]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 1:16 (#1)

עַל־כֵּן יְזַבֵּחַ לְחֶרְמֹו וִיקַטֵּר לְמִכְמַרְתֹּו

“Therefore he sacrifices to his net and burns incense to his dragnet”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of clauses in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [Therefore he worships his own weapons of war]

See: Parallelism

Habakkuk 1:16 (#2)

עַל־כֵּן יְזַבֵּחַ לְחֶרְמֹו וִיקַטֵּר לְמִכְמַרְתֹּו

“Therefore he sacrifices to his net and burns incense to his dragnet”

Habakkuk speaks of the Chaldean worshiping his **net** and **dragnet** as if those things were gods which could receive **sacrifices** and **incense**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Therefore he gives credit to his weapons of war and honors them]

See: Personification

Habakkuk 1:16 (#3)

שְׁמֵנָה חֶלְקֹו וּמַאֲכָלֹו בְּרִאָה

“his portion {is} fat and his food is rich”

Habakkuk is speaking of the Chaldean’s plunder as if it were **fat** and **rich** food. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his portion is plentiful and his food is abundant]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 1:16 (#4)

חֶלְקֹו

“his portion”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **his portion**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what he receives]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 1:17 (#1)

הַעַל כֵּן יָרִיק חֶרְמֹו וְתָמִיד לַהֲרֹג גֹּויִם לֹא יַחְמֹול

“Therefore will he empty his net, and will he not spare to slay the nations continually”

Habakkuk is using the question form to challenge Yahweh about whether the Chaldean will continue conquering without mercy. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Therefore, he should not keep emptying his net, and he should not keep slaying the nations continually!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Habakkuk - Chapter 2 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter contains Yahweh's answer to Habakkuk's second complaint. After instructing the prophet to write down a vision, Yahweh pronounces five oracles against the oppressor (verses 6–20), each beginning with "Woe."

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

The Righteous Shall Live by Faith

Verse 4 contrasts the proud, whose soul is not upright, with the righteous, who shall live by faith. This verse is quoted three times in the New Testament.

Idolatry

The final woe oracle (verses 18–20) condemns the making and worshiping of idols, contrasting them with Yahweh, who is in his holy temple.

Habakkuk 2:1 (#1)

עַל־מִשְׁמַרְתִּתִי אֶעֱמֹדָה וְאֶתְיַצְּבָה עַל־מָצוֹר

"I shall stand at my watchpost and shall station myself on the watchtower"

Habakkuk is speaking of his act of waiting for God's reply as if he were a guard standing at a **watchtower**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will wait attentively for what God will say to me]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 2:1 (#2)

תוֹכַחְתִּי

"my complaint"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **complaint**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what I am complaining about]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 2:2 (#1)

וַיַּעֲנֵנִי יְהוָה וַיֹּאמֶר

"Then Yahweh answered me and said"

The phrase **and said** introduces a direct quotation. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language. It may not be necessary to represent this term explicitly. Alternate translation: [Then Yahweh answered me,]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Habakkuk 2:2 (#2)

וַיַּעֲנֵנִי יְהוָה וַיֹּאמֶר כְּתֹב חָזוֹן וּבָאֵר עַל־הַלֻּחוֹת

"Then Yahweh answered me and said, "Write the vision, and make {it} plain on the tablets"

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [Then Yahweh answered me and told me to write the vision and to make it plain on the tablets] or [Then Yahweh answered me, telling me to write the vision and make it plain on the tablets]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Habakkuk 2:2 (#3)

לְמַעַן יָרוּץ קוֹרֵא בּוֹ

"so that the one reading it may run"

Here, **so that** marks **the one reading it may run** as the goal or purpose of writing the vision and making it plain on the tablets. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [in order that the one reading it may run]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Habakkuk 2:2 (#4)

יָרוּץ קוֹרֵא בּוֹ

"the one reading it may run"

Here, **run** represents the urgent heralding response of the one who reads the message. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the one reading it may hasten to proclaim it]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk 2:3 (#1)

וְיָפֵחַ לַקֵּץ וְלֹא יְכַזֵּב אִם־יִתְמַהְמָהּ חַכֵּה־לוֹ כִּי־בֹא יָבֹא לֹא יְאַחֵר

“it speaks of the end and will not lie. Though it tarries, wait for it. For coming, it will come; it will not delay”

Yahweh is speaking of **the vision** as if it were a living thing that could **speak** about the end, **lie**, tarry, and **delay**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [it is a message about the end that will certainly prove true; even if its fulfillment seems slow in coming, it will surely be fulfilled at the appointed time]

See: Personification

Habakkuk 2:3 (#2)

אִם־יִתְמַהְמָהּ חַכֵּה־לּוֹ

“Though it tarries, wait for it”

The author uses the word **Though** here to indicate a contrast between the possibility that the vision may seem delayed and the certainty that it will come eventually. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Even if it tarries, wait for it] or [Even if it seems to be delayed, do not give up waiting for it]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Habakkuk 2:3 (#3)

חַכֵּה־לּוֹ

“wait for it”

This is an imperative, but it communicates an exhortation or encouragement rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates encouragement. Alternate translation: [you should wait for it]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Habakkuk 2:3 (#4)

בֹּא יָבֹא

“coming, it will come”

The author is repeating forms of the verb **come** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [it will certainly come]

See: Reduplication

Habakkuk 2:4 (#1)

הִנֵּה

“Behold”

The author is using the term **Behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Look!]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 2:4 (#2)

עֻפְּלָה & נַפְשׁוֹ

“His soul is puffed up”

Here the author is speaking of a proud person as if his **soul** were something that could be physically **puffed up** or inflated. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He is arrogant]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 2:4 (#3)

נַפְשׁוֹ

“His soul”

Here, **soul** represents the entire person from the perspective of his inner character. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [He himself]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk 2:4 (#4)

עֻפְּלָה לֹא־יָשְׁרָה נַפְשׁוֹ בּוֹ

“His soul is puffed up; it is not upright within him”

The pronouns **His** and **him** both refer to the proud, arrogant person described in this verse, who is contrasted with **the righteous** in the following clause. In the context of the book, this probably means the Chaldeans. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state this explicitly. Alternate translation: [The Chaldeans’ souls are puffed up; it is not upright within them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Habakkuk 2:4 (#5)

עֻפְּלָה

“is puffed up”

The expression **is puffed up** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could

express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [has become proud]

See: Active or Passive

Habakkuk 2:4 (#6)

לֹא־יָשְׁרָה & בּוֹ

“it is not upright within him”

Here the author is speaking of moral character as if it were something that could be physically **upright** or straight. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his character is not right within him]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 2:4 (#7)

וְצַדִּ֖יק

“but the righteous”

The author is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the righteous person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Habakkuk 2:4 (#8)

וְצַדִּ֖יק בֶּאֱמוּנָתוֹ֙ יִחְיֶ֔ה

“but the righteous will live by his faithfulness”

The author uses the word **but** here to indicate a contrast between the proud person whose soul is not upright and the righteous person who lives by faithfulness. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [however, the righteous person will live by his faithfulness]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Habakkuk 2:4 (#9)

בֶּאֱמוּנָתוֹ֙

“by his faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [being faithful to God]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 2:5 (#1)

אֲשֶׁר֩ הִרְחִ֨יב כִּשְׁא֜וֹל נַפְשׁ֗וֹ

“who enlarges his appetite like Sheol”

The point of this comparison is that just as **Sheol** is never full and always takes in more of the dead, so the arrogant warrior is never content and always desires more conquests. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [who makes his desire as vast as the grave]

See: Simile

Habakkuk 2:5 (#2)

הַיַּ֣יִן בּוֹגֵ֔ד גֶּ֥בֶר יָהִ֖יר

“wine deceives the arrogant warrior”

Yahweh is speaking of **wine** as if it were a person capable of betraying or deceiving someone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [wine causes the arrogant warrior to go astray]

See: Personification

Habakkuk 2:5 (#3)

אֲשֶׁר֩ הִרְחִ֨יב כִּשְׁא֜וֹל נַפְשׁ֗וֹ וְה֤וּא כַמָּ֙וֶת֙ וְלֹ֣א יִשְׂבָּ֔ע

“who enlarges his appetite like Sheol, and he {is} like death and is never satisfied”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of clauses in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [whose appetite is never filled, like Sheol and death]

See: Parallelism

Habakkuk 2:5 (#4)

נַפְשׁ֗וֹ

“his appetite”

Here, **appetite** represents desire or craving. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [his desire] or [his sense of need]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk 2:5 (#5)

וְה֤וּא כַמָּ֙וֶת֙ וְלֹ֣א יִשְׂבָּ֔ע

“and he {is} like death and is never satisfied”

The point of this comparison is that just as **death** is relentless and never stops taking people, so this person is relentless and **never satisfied** in his greed. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [he is as relentless as death and is never satisfied]

See: Simile

Habakkuk 2:5 (#6)

וַיֶּאֱסֹף אֵלָיו֙ כָּל־הַגּוֹיִ֔ם וַיִּקְבֹּ֥ץ אֵלָ֖יו כָּל־הָעַמִּֽים

“And he gathers to himself all of the nations and collects for himself all of the peoples”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of clauses in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [And he gathers to himself every nation and every people] or [And he gathers to himself all of the nations; yes, he collects for himself all of the peoples]

See: Parallelism

Habakkuk 2:6 (#1)

הֲלוֹא־אֵ֙לֶּה כֻּלָּ֔ם עָלָיו֙ מָשָׁ֣ל יִשָּׂ֔אוּ וּמְלִיצָ֖ה חִידָ֣ת לֹ֑ו וְיֹאמַ֗ר הֹ֚וי הַמַּרְבֶּ֣ה לֹא־לֹ֔ו עַד־מָתַ֖י וּמַכְבִּ֥יד עָלָ֖יו עַבְטִֽיט

“Will not these, all of them, take up a proverb against him, and ridicule, a riddle about him, so that it says, ‘Woe to the one increasing {what is} not his’—until when? ‘and loading onto himself pledges”

Yahweh is using the question form to emphasize that the conquered peoples will certainly mock the oppressor. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [These, all of them, will certainly take up a proverb against him, and ridicule, a riddle about him, so that it says, ‘Woe to the one increasing what is not his’—‘until when? and loading onto himself pledges’!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Habakkuk 2:6 (#2)

וְיֹאמַ֗ר הֹ֚וי הַמַּרְבֶּ֣ה לֹא־לֹ֔ו עַד־מָתַ֖י וּמַכְבִּ֥יד עָלָ֖יו עַבְטִֽיט

“so that it says, ‘Woe to the one increasing {what is} not his’—until when? ‘and loading onto himself pledges”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [so that it pronounces woe on the one increasing what is not his —until when? and loading onto himself pledges]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Habakkuk 2:6 (#3)

הֹ֚וי הַמַּרְבֶּ֣ה לֹא־לֹ֔ו עַד־מָתַ֖י וּמַכְבִּ֥יד עָלָ֖יו עַבְטִֽיט

“Woe to the one increasing {what is} not his’—until when? ‘and loading onto himself pledges”

Here the conquered peoples use a proverb in order to mock the greedy conqueror. Translate this proverb in a way that will be recognized as a proverb and be meaningful in your language and culture. Alternate translation: [Disaster awaits the one who endlessly takes what does not belong to him and burdens himself with debts]

See: Proverbs

Habakkuk 2:6 (#4)

עַד־מָתַ֖י

“until when”

The conquered peoples are interjecting this brief question form to express frustration that the oppressor’s greed has continued for too long. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [for far too long!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Habakkuk 2:7 (#1)

הֲלֹ֣וא פֶתַ֔ע יָקֻ֖מוּ נֹשְׁכֶ֑יךָ

“Will not your biters suddenly rise up”

Here the author is introducing **your biters** as new participants. The phrase refers to the people whom the oppressor has exploited, who will now turn against him. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Will not those whom you oppressed suddenly rise up]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

Habakkuk 2:7 (#2)

הֲלֹ֣וא פֶתַ֔ע יָקֻ֖מוּ נֹשְׁכֶ֑יךָ וְיִקְצ֣וּ מְזַעְזְעֶ֔יךָ

“Will not your biters suddenly rise up, and the ones shaking you awaken”

The author is using the question form to emphasize that those who oppose the oppressor will certainly

rebel. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Your biters will suddenly rise up, and the ones shaking you will awaken!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Habakkuk 2:7 (#3)

נֹשְׁכֶיךָ

“your biters”

The Hebrew word translated **biters** could mean: (1) your creditors, that is, the plundered peoples who will demand repayment as if they were animals that bite. Alternate translation: [your creditors] (2) those who you have oppressed by forcing them to pay you unjustly. Alternate translation: [those you forced to be in debt to you]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 2:7 (#4)

מְזַעְזְעֶיךָ

“the ones shaking you”

Here the author is speaking of those who will demand payment as if they were people who were **shaking** someone. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the ones who will make you tremble]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 2:7 (#5)

וְהָיִיתָ לְמִשִּׁסָּה֖ לָמֹֽו

“Then you will become spoils for them”

Here the author is speaking of the oppressor as if he were plunder that could be taken as **spoils** of war. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Then they will take everything from you]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 2:8 (#1)

מִדְּמֵ֤י אָדָם֙ וַחֲמַס־אֶ֣רֶץ קִרְיָ֔ה וְכָל־יֹשְׁבֵ֖י בָּֽהּ

“from the bloodshed of man and the violence of the land, the city, and all the dwellers in it”

Here the author is clarifying who suffered from the oppressor’s actions. The phrase identifies the victims and the places that were harmed. Your language may have its own way of specifying the victims that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [because of the people you murdered and the violent way you treated the land, the city, and all who live in it]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

Habakkuk 2:8 (#2)

מִדְּמֵ֤י אָדָם֙

“from the bloodshed of man”

Here, **bloodshed** represents the act of murdering people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [because of your murderous ways]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk 2:9 (#1)

הֹ֚וי בֹּצֵ֣עַ בֶּ֔צַע רָ֖ע לְבֵיתֹ֑ו

“Woe to the one gaining an evil gain for his house”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [They will say that terrible things will happen to the one gaining an evil gain for his house]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Habakkuk 2:9 (#2)

הֹ֚וי בֹּצֵ֣עַ בֶּ֔צַע רָ֖ע לְבֵיתֹ֑ו

“Woe to the one gaining an evil gain for his house”

The phrase **Woe to the one gaining an evil gain for his house** expresses a strong feeling of warning and coming judgment. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [How terrible it will be for the one gaining an evil gain for his house]

See: Exclamations

Habakkuk 2:9 (#3)

בֹּצֵ֣עַ בֶּ֔צַע רָ֖ע

“the one gaining an evil gain”

The author is repeating forms of the word **gain** in order to intensify the idea of greedy, exploitative profit. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of

expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [the one greedily getting evil profit]

See: Reduplication

Habakkuk 2:9 (#4)

בָּצַע רָע

“an evil gain”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **an evil gain**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [money evilly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 2:9 (#5)

לְשַׁשּׂוּם בַּמָּרוֹם קִנּוֹ

“to set his nest on high”

Here the author is speaking of the oppressor building his house in a secure, elevated place as if he were a bird setting **his nest on high**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to make his dwelling secure in a high place]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 2:9 (#6)

לְהִנָּצֵל

“to be delivered”

The expression **to be delivered** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [to deliver himself]

See: Active or Passive

Habakkuk 2:9 (#7)

מִכַּף־רָע

“from the hand of evil”

Here, **hand** represents the power or control of evil. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from the power of evil]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk 2:9 (#8)

מִכַּף־רָע

“from the hand of evil”

The author is using the possessive form to describe a **hand** that is characterized by **evil**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from the evil grasp]

See: Possession

Habakkuk 2:10 (#1)

בֹּשֶׁת

“shame”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **shame**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what is shameful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 2:10 (#2)

קֵצוֹת־עַמִּים רַבִּים

“cutting off many peoples”

Habakkuk is speaking of destroying nations as if it were **cutting** them **off**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [destroying many peoples]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 2:10 (#3)

וְחוֹטֵאתָ נַפְשֶׁךָ

“and sinning against your soul”

Here, **soul** represents the person himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [sinning against yourself]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk 2:11 (#1)

אֶבֶן מִקִּיר תִּזְעָק וְכָפִיס מֵעֵץ יַעֲנֶנָּה

“a stone will cry out from the wall, and a beam from the wood will answer it”

The author is speaking of **a stone** and **a beam** as if they were living things that could **cry out** and **answer**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [even the stolen stones in your wall and the wooden beams are evidence of your wrongdoing]

See: Personification

Habakkuk 2:12 (#1)

הַהֹוי בֹּנֶה עִיר בְּדָמִים

“Woe to the one building a city with bloodshed”

The word **Woe** here communicates a warning about coming disaster. If a speaker of your language would not express this as an exclamation, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Terrible things will happen to the one building a city with bloodshed]

See: Exclamations

Habakkuk 2:12 (#2)

בֹּנֶה עִיר

“the one building a city”

The author is not referring to one specific person but to anyone who does this. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this idea using a different form. Alternate translation: [anyone who builds a city]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Habakkuk 2:12 (#3)

בְּדָמִים

“with bloodshed”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **bloodshed**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [by working people so hard they die]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 2:12 (#4)

בָּעַוְלָה

“with injustice”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **injustice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [by acting unjustly]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 2:13 (#1)

הִנֵּה

“Behold”

The author is using the term **Behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use here. Alternate translation: [Pay attention]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 2:13 (#2)

הֲלֹלְוֹא הִנֵּה מֵאֵת יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת וְיִגְעֲוּ עַמִּים בְּדֵי־אֵשׁ וּלְאֻמִּמִּים בְּדֵי־רִיק יִעָפוּ

“Behold, {is it} not from Yahweh of armies that peoples labor for fire and nations become weary for emptiness”

The author is using the question form to emphasize that this is certainly true. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement. Alternate translation: [Behold, it is from Yahweh of armies that peoples labor for fire and nations weary themselves for emptiness.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Habakkuk 2:13 (#3)

וְיִגְעֲוּ עַמִּים בְּדֵי־אֵשׁ

“that peoples labor for fire”

Here the author is speaking as if the results of people’s work were fuel that would be consumed by **fire**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use here, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [that peoples work hard for nothing]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 2:13 (#4)

בְּדֵי־רִיק

“for emptiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **emptiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for nothing]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 2:14 (#1)

תִּמָּלֵא הָאָרֶץ

“the earth will be filled”

If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God will fill the earth]

See: Active or Passive

Habakkuk 2:14 (#2)

לְדַעַת אֶת־כְּבְוֹד יְהוָה

“with knowing the glory of Yahweh”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [with people who know how glorious Yahweh is]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 2:14 (#3)

אֶת־כְּבֹוד יְהוָה

“the glory of Yahweh”

The author is using the possessive form to describe **glory** that belongs to **Yahweh**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh’s glory]

See: Possession

Habakkuk 2:14 (#4)

כַּמַּיִם יְכַסֹּו עַל־יָם

“as the waters cover over the sea”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the waters** completely **cover over the sea**, so the knowledge of Yahweh’s glory will completely fill the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [just as water completely fills the ocean]

See: Simile

Habakkuk 2:15 (#1)

הֹוי מַשְׁקֵה רֵעֵהוּ

“Woe to the one causing his neighbor to drink”

The word **Woe** here communicates a warning about coming disaster. If a speaker of your language would not express this as an exclamation, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Terrible things will happen to the one causing his neighbor to drink]

See: Exclamations

Habakkuk 2:15 (#2)

מַשְׁקֵה רֵעֵהוּ

“the one causing his neighbor to drink”

Habakkuk is not referring to one specific person but to anyone who does this. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this idea using a different form. Alternate translation: [anyone who causes his neighbor to drink]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Habakkuk 2:15 (#3)

מַשְׁקֵה רֵעֵהוּ מְסַפֵּחַ חֲמָתְךָ וְאַף שַׁכֵּר

“the one causing his neighbor to drink, pouring out your wineskin, and even making {him} drunk”

Here the author is speaking of exploiting and humiliating other nations as if it were **causing** them **to drink** and **making** them **drunk**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use here, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one exploiting the vulnerability of his neighbor, intoxicating him, and promoting his drunkenness]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 2:15 (#4)

מְסַפֵּחַ חֲמָתְךָ

“pouring out your wineskin”

Habakkuk has been speaking about the oppressor in the third person (**his** neighbor) but shifts to addressing him directly in the second person with **your**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use consistent pronouns throughout. Alternate translation: [pouring out his wineskin]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Habakkuk 2:15 (#5)

לְמַעַן הַבִּיט עַל־מְעוֹרֵיהֶם

“in order to look upon their nakedness”

Here, **in order to** marks **look upon their nakedness** as the goal or purpose of **causing his neighbor to drink** and **making him drunk**. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the goal of the previous actions. Alternate translation: [so that you can look upon their nakedness]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Habakkuk 2:15 (#6)

הַבִּיט עַל־מְעוֹרֵיהֶם

“look upon their nakedness”

Here, **nakedness** represents humiliation and defeat. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [humiliate them] or [enjoy their downfall]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk 2:15 (#7)

עַל־מְעוֹרֵיהֶם

“upon their nakedness”

Habakkuk has been using second person (**your**) to address the oppressor but shifts to third person plural with **their**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use consistent pronouns. Alternate translation: [his nakedness]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Habakkuk 2:16 (#1)

שְׁתֵה גַם־אַתָּה וְהֵעָרֵל

“Drink, you also, and be uncircumcised”

These imperatives, **Drink** and **be uncircumcised**, communicate a prediction of what will happen, rather than a command. If the imperative form does not communicate this in your language, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [You also will drink and be exposed]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Habakkuk 2:16 (#2)

שְׁתֵה גַם־אַתָּה

“Drink, you also”

The word **Drink** here is a metaphor. The author is speaking of experiencing God’s judgment as if it were drinking from a cup. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use here, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Experience judgment, you also]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 2:16 (#3)

וְהֵעָרֵל

“and be uncircumcised”

Here the author is speaking of being exposed and shamed as if it were being **uncircumcised**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use here, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and the shame of your uncircumcision be exposed]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 2:16 (#4)

תִּסָּבּוֹב עָלַיִךְ כּוֹס יְמִין יְהוָה

“The cup of the right hand of Yahweh will come around to you”

Here the author is speaking of God’s judgment as if it were a **cup** of wine being passed around for the oppressor to drink. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use here, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will turn his powerful judgment upon you]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 2:16 (#5)

כּוֹס יְמִין יְהוָה

“The cup of the right hand of Yahweh”

The author is using the possessive form to describe **the cup of the right hand of Yahweh**. This means the cup that Yahweh holds in his right hand to dispense judgment. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the cup that Yahweh holds in his powerful hand]

See: Possession

Habakkuk 2:16 (#6)

יְמִין יְהוָה

“the right hand of Yahweh”

Here, **the right hand** represents the power of **Yahweh**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the power of Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk 2:16 (#7)

וְקִיקָלָלוֹן עַל־כְּבוֹדֵךְ

“and disgrace upon your glory”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **disgrace** and **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and what is disgraceful will cover what is glorious about you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 2:17 (#1)

כִּי חֲמַס לְבָנוֹן יְכַסֶּךָּ

“For the violence of Lebanon will cover you”

The word translated as **For** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that the violence against Lebanon is the reason for the judgment described in the previous verses. Alternate translation:

[Because the violence done to Lebanon will overwhelm you]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Habakkuk 2:17 (#2)

חֲמַס לְבָנוֹן יְכַסֶּךָּ

“the violence of Lebanon will cover you”

Here the author is speaking of violence returning upon the oppressor as if it were a garment that would **cover** him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use here, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the violent things you did to Lebanon will happen to you]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 2:17 (#3)

יְחִיתַתָּן

“will terrify them”

The pronoun **them** likely refers to the Babylonians, the same people addressed as **you** earlier in the verse. If it would be helpful in your language, you could clarify the referent. Alternate translation: [will terrify you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Habakkuk 2:18 (#1)

מָה־הוֹעִיל פֶּסֶל כִּי פְסָלוֹ יֹצְרוֹ מַסֵּכָה וּמֹרֶה שָׁקֶר

“What does a carved image profit when its fashioner has carved it, a molten idol and a teacher of lies”

Habakkuk is using the question form to emphasize that a carved image has no value at all. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement. Alternate translation: [A carved image does not profit at all even though its fashioner has carved it, a molten idol and a teacher of lies.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Habakkuk 2:18 (#2)

יֹצְרוֹ

“its fashioner”

The author is using the possessive form to describe the relationship between an idol and the person who made it. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the person who fashioned it]

See: Possession

Habakkuk 2:18 (#3)

מַסֵּכָה וּמֹרֶה שָׁקֶר

“a molten idol and a teacher of lies”

The phrases **a molten idol and a teacher of lies** restate and further describe the **carved image** from earlier in the verse. If it would be helpful in your language, you could show this connection explicitly. Alternate translation: [that is, a molten idol, a teacher of lies]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Habakkuk 2:18 (#4)

וּמֹרֶה שָׁקֶר

“and a teacher of lies”

The author is speaking of an idol as if it were a living person who could teach **lies**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and something that deceives]

See: Personification

Habakkuk 2:18 (#5)

וּמֹרֶה שָׁקֶר

“and a teacher of lies”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **lies**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and a teacher of what is false]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 2:18 (#6)

יֹצֵר יְצִרוֹ

“the one forming its form”

Habakkuk is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [the craftsman who shaped his own creation]

See: Poetry

Habakkuk 2:18 (#7)

יְצִרוֹ

“its form”

The author is using the possessive form to describe the thing that someone has formed. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the thing he has formed]

See: Possession

Habakkuk 2:18 (#8)

לַעֲשׂוֹת אֱלִילִים אִלְּמִים

“to make mute idols”

Here, **to make mute idols** marks the purpose or result of the fashioner trusting in what he has formed. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the outcome of that trust. Alternate translation: [so that he ends up making mute idols]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Habakkuk 2:19 (#1)

הַהוֹי אֹמֵר לָעֵץ הָקִיצָה עוּרִי לְאֶבֶן דּוּמָּם

“Woe to the one saying to the wood, Awake, to the silent stone, Arise”

The word **Woe** here communicates a warning about coming disaster. If a speaker of your language would not express this as an exclamation, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Terrible things will happen to the one saying to the wood, Awake, to the silent stone, Arise]

See: Exclamations

Habakkuk 2:19 (#2)

אֹמֵר לָעֵץ

“the one saying to the wood”

The author is not referring to one specific person but to anyone who does this. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this idea using a different form. Alternate translation: [anyone who says to the wood]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Habakkuk 2:19 (#3)

אֹמֵר לָעֵץ הָקִיצָה עוּרִי לְאֶבֶן דּוּמָּם

“the one saying to the wood, Awake, to the silent stone, Arise”

The author is speaking of **wood** and **stone** as if they were living things that could wake up and arise. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the one commanding a wooden idol to wake up and a stone idol to stand up]

See: Personification

Habakkuk 2:19 (#4)

הוּא יוֹרֶה

“It teaches”

The author actually means to communicate the opposite of the literal meaning of what he is saying here. **It teaches** is said about an idol that cannot speak, making the statement ironic. If a speaker of your language would not use irony for this purpose, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [It cannot teach anything!]

See: Irony

Habakkuk 2:19 (#5)

הִנֵּה

“Behold”

The author is using the term **Behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use here. Alternate translation: [Pay attention] or [Observe]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 2:19 (#6)

הוּא תָּפוּשׂ זָהָב וָכֶסֶף

“it is overlaid with gold and silver”

If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [its maker has overlaid it with gold and silver]

See: Active or Passive

Habakkuk 2:19 (#7)

וְכָל־רוּחַ אֵין בְּקִרְבּוֹ

“but there is not any breath within it”

Here, **breath** represents life. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [but there is not any life within it]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk 2:20 (#1)

בְּהֵיכַל קָדְשׁוֹ

“is in the temple of his holiness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **holiness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the temple that is set apart for him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 2:20 (#2)

בְּהֵיכַל קָדְשׁוֹ

“is in the temple of his holiness”

The author is using the possessive form to describe the **temple** that belongs to Yahweh and is characterized by **holiness**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [is in the temple where he dwells in holiness]

See: Possession

Habakkuk 2:20 (#3)

הַהַס מִפָּנָיו כָּל־הָאָרֶץ

“Hush, all the earth from his face”

The word **Hush** here communicates a command for reverent silence. If a speaker of your language would not express this as an exclamation, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Let all the earth be silent from his face]

See: Exclamations

Habakkuk 2:20 (#4)

כָּל־הָאָרֶץ

“all the earth”

Here, **all the earth** represents all the people living on the earth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [everyone everywhere]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk 2:20 (#5)

מִפָּנָיו

“from his face”

Here, **his face** represents the presence of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from his presence] or [before him]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk - Chapter 3 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter is a prayer-psalm (verse 1) describing a theophany, Yahweh’s appearance as a divine warrior. It includes a superscription (verse 1), a liturgical colophon or ending statement (end of verse 19), and three Selah markers, indicating it was used in temple worship.

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Theophany

Verses 3–15 describe God coming from Teman with cosmic power, shaking mountains, splitting rivers, and commanding the sun and moon. These images draw on the tradition of Yahweh’s actions at the Red Sea.

From Terror to Trust

The chapter pivots at verse 16: Habakkuk trembles with fear at God’s power, yet resolves to wait quietly and rejoice even when all provision fails (verses 17–19).

Habakkuk 3:1 (#1)

שִׁגְיֹנוֹת

“shigyonoth”

The word **shigyonoth** is from the original language. You will need to decide if you will use this word in its original-language form or if you will instead translate the meaning into your language. Either approach has broad support. The meaning of the word is uncertain, but it may refer to a type of passionate or emotional song. If you use the original-language word, you could spell it the way it sounds in your language and then put the translation in a footnote.

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Habakkuk 3:2 (#1)

שִׁמְעֲךָ֙

“your report”

Here, **your report** represents the mighty deeds that people have reported about Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the report of your mighty deeds]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk 3:2 (#2)

פָּעָלְךָ

“your work”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **work**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what you have done]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 3:2 (#3)

בְּקֶרֶב שָׁנִים

“In the midst of the years”

Habakkuk is using **In the midst of the years** as a common expression of the culture to mean “In our own time” or “In the present era.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [In our own time]

See: Idiom

Habakkuk 3:2 (#4)

חַיֵּיהוּ

“revive it”

The pronoun **it** refers to Yahweh’s work mentioned earlier in the verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [revive your work]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Habakkuk 3:2 (#5)

חַיֵּיהוּ

“revive it”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please revive it]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Habakkuk 3:2 (#6)

תּוֹדִיעַ

“make it known”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please make it known]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Habakkuk 3:2 (#7)

בְּרֹגֶז רַחֵם תִּזְכֹּר

“In wrath, remember compassion”

Habakkuk uses the phrase **In wrath, remember compassion** to indicate a contrast between **wrath** and **compassion**. The implicit meaning is “even in wrath.” In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Even in your wrath, remember compassion]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Habakkuk 3:2 (#8)

בְּרֹגֶז

“In wrath”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wrath**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [In your wrathful condition]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 3:2 (#9)

רַחֵם תִּזְכֹּר

“remember compassion”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please remember compassion]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Habakkuk 3:2 (#10)

רַחֵם

“compassion”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **compassion**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to be merciful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 3:2 (#11)

בְּקֶ֣רֶב שָׁנִ֔ים חַיֵּ֖יהוּ בְּקֶ֣רֶב שָׁנִ֑ים תּוֹדִֽיעַ

“In the midst of the years, revive it; in the midst of the years, make it known”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of clauses in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [In our own time, renew your work and make it known]

See: Parallelism

Habakkuk 3:3 (#1)

אֱלֹוהַ֙ מִתֵּימָ֣ן יָבֹ֔וא וְקָדֹ֥ושׁ מֵהַר־פָּארָ֖ן

“God came from Teman, and the Holy One, from Mount Paran”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of clauses in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [God, the Holy One, came from the desert region south of Israel]

See: Parallelism

Habakkuk 3:3 (#2)

מִתֵּימָ֣ן

“from Teman”

The word **Teman** is the name of a region in Edom, south of Israel.

See: How to Translate Names

Habakkuk 3:3 (#3)

וְקָדֹ֥ושׁ מֵהַר־פָּארָ֖ן

“and the Holy One, from Mount Paran”

Habakkuk is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and the Holy One traveled from Mount Paran]

See: Ellipsis

Habakkuk 3:3 (#4)

מֵהַר־פָּארָ֖ן

“from Mount Paran”

The term **Mount Paran** is the name of a mountainous region south of Edom, possibly the southern portion of the Sinai Peninsula.

See: How to Translate Names

Habakkuk 3:3 (#5)

כִּסָּ֤ה שָׁמַ֙יִם֙ הוֹדֹ֔ו

“His splendor covered the heavens”

Habakkuk is speaking of God’s **splendor** as if it were a blanket that could **cover** the heavens. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He spread his splendor across the heavens]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 3:3 (#6)

וּתְהִלָּתֹ֖ו מָלְאָ֥ה הָאָֽרֶץ

“and his praise filled the earth”

Habakkuk is speaking of God’s **praise** as if the earth were a vessel that his praise could **fill**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and people throughout the earth praised him]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 3:4 (#1)

וְנֹ֥גַהּ כָּאֹ֖ור תִּהְיֶ֑ה

“And {his} brightness was like the light”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **brightness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [And he shone as brightly as the light]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 3:4 (#2)

וְנֹ֥גַהּ כָּאֹ֖ור תִּהְיֶ֑ה

“And {his} brightness was like the light”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the light** is intensely radiant, so was God’s **brightness**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [And his brightness was intensely radiant]

See: Simile

Habakkuk 3:4 (#3)

מִיָּדֹו

“from his hand”

Here, **his hand** represents his power or his side. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from his side]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk 3:4 (#4)

לֹו

“his”

The pronoun **his** refers to God. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [God’s]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Habakkuk 3:4 (#5)

וְשָׁשָׂם חֶבְיֹון עֻזֹּה

“and there {was} the hiding of his strength”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **hiding** and **strength**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [and there he hid how strong he is]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 3:5 (#1)

לְפָנָיו

“Before his face”

Here, **face** represents the presence of God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [In his presence]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk 3:5 (#2)

לְפָנָיו

“Before his face”

The pronoun **his** refers to God, who is described in the previous verses. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Before God’s face]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Habakkuk 3:5 (#3)

יֵלֶךְ דָּבֶר

“went”

The author is speaking of **plague** as if it were a living thing that could walk. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [God sent plague]

See: Personification

Habakkuk 3:5 (#4)

וְיֵצֵא רָשָׁף

“and & went out”

The author is speaking of **fiery bolts** as if they were a living thing that could go out. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and God sent out fiery bolts]

See: Personification

Habakkuk 3:5 (#5)

רָשָׁף

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: רֶשֶׁף”

The word translated as **fiery bolts** can refer to different things. This could mean: (1) a burning fever or disease. Alternate translation: [a burning fever] or (2) flaming projectiles or burning coals, describing God’s destructive power against his enemies. Alternate translation: [burning coals went out at his feet] or (3) lightning bolts. Alternate translation: [lightning bolts]

Habakkuk 3:6 (#1)

וַיְמֹּדֵד

“and he measured”

The word translated as **measured** is understood in two different ways by Bible scholars. This could mean: (1) God measured out the earth, surveying its full extent. Alternate translation: [he measured the earth] or (2) God shook the earth. Alternate translation: [he shook the earth]

See: Alternative Readings

Habakkuk 3:6 (#2)

וַיִּתְפֹּצְצוּ הָרְרֵי־עַד שַׁחוּ גִּבְעֹות עוֹלָם

“The eternal mountains & everlasting”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of clauses in Hebrew poetry that mean

basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [The most ancient mountains crumbled]

See: Parallelism

Habakkuk 3:6 (#3)

וַיִּתְפֹּצְצוּ֙ הָרְרֵי־עַ֔ד

"The eternal mountains"

If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God shattered the eternal mountains]

See: Active or Passive

Habakkuk 3:6 (#4)

הֲלִיכ֥וֹת עוֹלָ֖ם לֽוֹ

"His goings {are} everlasting"

The author is speaking of God's **goings** as if God's ways of acting were physical journeys. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [His ways are everlasting]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 3:7 (#1)

תַּחַ֤ת אָוֶן֙

"trouble"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **trouble**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [While they suffered]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 3:7 (#2)

אָהֳלֵ֣י כוּשָׁ֔ן

"the tents of"

The author is using **the tents of Cushan** to represent the people who live in them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people of Cushan]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk 3:7 (#3)

כוּשָׁ֔ן

"QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: כוּשָׁ֔ן"

The word **Cushan** is the name of a people group or region. It may be related to Cush (Ethiopia).

See: How to Translate Names

Habakkuk 3:7 (#4)

יְרִיעֹ֥ות אֶֽרֶץ־מִדְיָ֖ן

"the curtains of the land of Midian"

The author is using **the curtains of the land of Midian** to represent the people who live in the tents. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people of the land of Midian]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk 3:7 (#5)

מִדְיָ֖ן

"Midian"

The word **Midian** is the name of a place in southern Saudi Arabia. That name came from Midian, a son of Abraham born to Katurah.

See: How to Translate Names

Habakkuk 3:8 (#1)

הֲבִנְהָרִ֤ים׀ חָרָ֣ה יְהוָ֗ה אִ֚ם בַּנְּהָרִ֣ים׀ אַפֶּ֔ךָ

"Was it against the rivers that Yahweh burned? Or {was} your nose against the rivers"

The author refers to God in the third person as **Yahweh** in the first phrase and then shifts to the second person **your** in the next phrase. If this would be confusing in your language, you could use the second person throughout. Alternate translation: [Was it against the rivers that you burned? Or was your anger against the rivers?]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Habakkuk 3:8 (#2)

הֲבִנְהָרִ֤ים׀ חָרָ֣ה יְהוָ֗ה

"Was it against the rivers that Yahweh burned"

The author is using this question as a way of emphasizing that Yahweh's anger was not truly directed at the rivers. If you would not use a rhetorical question for this purpose in your language, you could translate this as a statement. Alternate translation: [It was not against the rivers that Yahweh burned.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Habakkuk 3:8 (#3)

חָרָ֣ה יְהוָ֔ה

“that Yahweh burned”

The author is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a fire that **burned**. This image represents God’s anger. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh was angry]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 3:8 (#4)

אִ֚ם בַּנְּהָרִ֣ים ׀ אַפֶּ֗ךָ

“Or {was} your nose against the rivers”

The author is using this question as a way of restating the previous question for emphasis. If you would not use a rhetorical question for this purpose in your language, you could translate this as a statement. Alternate translation: [Neither was your anger against the rivers.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Habakkuk 3:8 (#5)

אַפֶּ֗ךָ

“your nose”

Here, **your nose** represents Yahweh’s anger. The word for nose in the source language is also the word for anger, since a person’s nostrils flare when they are angry. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your anger]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk 3:8 (#6)

אִם־בַּיָּ֣ם עֶבְרָתֶ֔ךָ כִּֽי־תִרְכַּ֖ב עַל־סוּסֶ֑יךָ מַרְכְּבֹתֶ֖יךָ יְשׁוּעָֽה

“Or {was} your fury against the sea, that you rode on your horses, your chariots of salvation”

The author is using this question as a way of restating the previous questions for emphasis. If you would not use a rhetorical question for this purpose in your language, you could translate this as a statement. Alternate translation: [Neither was your fury against the sea, when you rode on your horses, your chariots of salvation.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Habakkuk 3:8 (#7)

אִם־בַּיָּ֣ם עֶבְרָתֶ֔ךָ

“Or {was} your fury against the sea”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **fury**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Or were you furious at the sea]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 3:8 (#8)

תִּרְכַּ֖ב ׀ עַל־סוּסֶ֑יךָ מַרְכְּבֹתֶ֖יךָ יְשׁוּעָֽה

“you rode on your horses, your chariots of salvation”

The author is speaking of God as if he were a warrior who rode on horses and drove chariots. This image represents God coming in power to fight for his people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you came in great power to save your people]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 3:8 (#9)

מַרְכְּבֹתֶ֖יךָ

“your chariots of”

Habakkuk is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [or on your chariots of]

See: Ellipsis

Habakkuk 3:8 (#10)

מַרְכְּבֹתֶ֖יךָ יְשׁוּעָֽה

“your chariots of salvation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **salvation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your chariots to save your people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 3:9 (#1)

עָרְיָ֥ה תֵעוֹרֵ֖ר קַשְׁתֶּ֑ךָ

“was completely bared”

If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you could express the idea in active form or

in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [You completely bared your bow] or [You made your bow ready for action]

See: Active or Passive

Habakkuk 3:9 (#2)

עֶרְיֵיָה תֵּעוֹרֵר קַשְׁתֶּךָ

“was completely bared”

The author is speaking of God as if he were a warrior who readied a **bow** for battle. This image represents God preparing to act in power against his enemies. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You prepared your weapons completely]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 3:9 (#3)

קַשְׁתֶּךָ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: קַשְׁתֶּךָ”

Habakkuk is speaking of **Your bow** as the means by which Yahweh would shoot arrows of lightning. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Your weapon for shooting lightning]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 3:9 (#4)

שְׁבֻעוֹת מַטּוֹת אֹמֶר

“the staffs {were} a word”

The meaning of this phrase is uncertain, and Bible scholars have understood it in different ways. Some read it as referring to God acting in fulfillment of the oaths he had sworn to the tribal leaders of Israel. Others understand it to mean that God readied his arrows for battle as he had vowed. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, you may wish to follow its reading. If not, you could state the meaning plainly, as the UST does.

See: Textual Variants

Habakkuk 3:10 (#1)

רָאוּךָ יָחִילוּ הָרִים

“The mountains saw you; they writhed”

The author is speaking of **the mountains** as if they were a person who could see and writhe in pain. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The mountains shook when you appeared]

See: Personification

Habakkuk 3:10 (#2)

נָתַן תְּהוֹמֹם קוֹלוֹ

“gave its voice”

The author is speaking of **the deep** as if it were a person who could speak. The **voice** represents the loud sound of the waters. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The deep waters sounded loud]

See: Personification

Habakkuk 3:10 (#3)

רוֹם יָדָיו נָשָׂא

“its hands on high”

The author is speaking of the deep waters as if they were a person who could lift **hands** on high. The raised hands represent the rising waves. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [its waves rose very high]

See: Personification

Habakkuk 3:11 (#1)

שֶׁמֶשׁ יָרֵחַ עָמָד

“and} moon stood still”

Habakkuk is speaking of **the sun** and **moon** as if they were living things that could have **stood still**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The sun and moon became stationary]

See: Personification

Habakkuk 3:11 (#2)

לְאוֹר חִצֶּיךָ יְהַלֵּכוּ לְנֹגַהּ בְּרַק חֲנִיתֶךָ

“at the light of & at the gleam of & your spear”

Here Habakkuk is speaking of lightning as if it were **arrows** and a **spear** that God uses as weapons. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [at the flash of your lightning bolts as they streaked, at the gleam of your flashing lightning]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 3:12 (#1)

בְּזַ֣עַם תִּצְעַד־אָ֔רֶץ בְּאַ֖ף

“the earth”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **indignation** and **anger**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [Because you were indignant, you marched through the earth; because you were angry,]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 3:12 (#2)

תָּדֹ֥ושׁ גּוֹיִֽם

“the nations”

Here Habakkuk is speaking of God’s destruction of the nations as if he were a farmer who **threshed** grain. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you crushed the nations]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 3:13 (#1)

לְיֵשַׁ֥ע עַמֶּ֖ךָ לְיֵשַׁ֣ע אֶת־מְשִׁיחֶ֑ךָ

“for the salvation of your people, for the salvation of your anointed one”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of clauses in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [to save your people, that is, to save your chosen king]

See: Parallelism

Habakkuk 3:13 (#2)

מָחַ֙צְתָּ֙ רֹ֣אשׁ מִבֵּ֔ית רָשָׁ֥ע עָרֶ֖ה יְסֹ֣וד עַד־צַוָּ֑אר

“You struck the head from the house of the wicked, laying bare the foundation to the neck”

Habakkuk is using two images together. He is speaking of the wicked person’s dynasty as if it were a **house** with a **foundation**, and he is speaking of God’s destruction of the leader as if it were an execution by beheading, **striking** the **head** and **laying bare** to the **neck**. Your language may have comparable expressions that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [destroyed the wicked leader and exposed all his followers]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 3:13 (#3)

רָשָׁ֑ע

“the wicked”

Habakkuk is using the adjective **wicked** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [of the wicked one]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Habakkuk 3:14 (#1)

בְּמַטָּ֖יו

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בְּמַטָּיו”

The pronoun **his** refers to the enemy leader. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [with the enemy’s own staffs]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Habakkuk 3:14 (#2)

רֹ֣אשׁ פְּרָזָ֔ו

“the head of”

Here, **head** represents the leader of the warriors. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the commander of his warriors]

See: Metonymy

Habakkuk 3:14 (#3)

יְסָעֲרֻ֣נִי

“They stormed”

The pronoun **They** refers to the enemy warriors. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The enemy warriors stormed]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Habakkuk 3:14 (#4)

יְסָעֲרֻ֣נִי

“They stormed”

Habakkuk is speaking of the enemy warriors’ attack as if they were a violent **storm**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They rushed violently]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 3:14 (#5)

לַהֲפִיצֵנִי

“to scatter me”

Habakkuk is using himself, one person, to represent all of his people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to scatter us]

See: Synecdoche

Habakkuk 3:14 (#6)

לַהֲפִיצֵנִי

“to scatter me”

Here, **to scatter me** marks scattering Habakkuk’s people as the goal or purpose of the enemy warriors storming. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that this is the purpose. Alternate translation: [in order to scatter me]

See: Connect — Goal (Purpose) Relationship

Habakkuk 3:14 (#7)

עֲלִיצָתָם כְּמוֹ

“their exultation”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **exultation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [they exulted as if]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 3:14 (#8)

כְּמוֹ־לֶאֱכֹל עָנְיִ בַּמִּסְתָּר

“to devour the afflicted”

The point of this comparison is that just as a wild animal devours helpless prey in hiding, so the enemy warriors eagerly attacked the helpless. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [was like those enjoy destroying helpless people privately]

See: Simile

Habakkuk 3:14 (#9)

עָנְיִ

“the afflicted”

Habakkuk is using the adjective **afflicted** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [afflicted people]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Habakkuk 3:15 (#1)

דָּרַכְתָּ בַיָּם סוּסֶיךָ

“with your horses”

Habakkuk is speaking of God as if God were a warrior riding **horses** through the **sea**. He is basing this image on the Israelites’ historic Red Sea crossing. The **horses** represent God’s power in battle and the **sea** represents God’s enemies. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You triumphed over your enemies]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 3:15 (#2)

חֹמֶר מַיִם רַבִּים

“through} the heap of & waters”

Habakkuk is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [you trod through the heap of great waters]

See: Ellipsis

Habakkuk 3:16 (#1)

וַתִּרְגַּז בִּטְנִי

“and my belly trembled”

Here Habakkuk is speaking of his inner emotional turmoil as if his **belly trembled**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I was deeply shaken inside]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 3:16 (#2)

יָבֹא רָקָב בַּעֲצָמַי

“Decay entered into my bones”

Habakkuk is speaking of **Decay** as if it were a living thing that could **entered into** his **bones**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My bones felt weak and rotten]

See: Personification

Habakkuk 3:16 (#3)

רָקָֽב

“Decay”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **Decay**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [A feeling of rot]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 3:16 (#4)

אֲשֶׁ֣ר אָנ֤וּחַ לְי֙וֹם צָרָ֔ה

“Yet I may rest for the day of distress”

Habakkuk uses the word **yet** here to indicate a contrast between his trembling and his quiet trust. Despite his overwhelming fear, he resolves to wait for God to act. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Even so, I will wait quietly for the day of distress]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Habakkuk 3:16 (#5)

לְי֙וֹם צָרָ֔ה

“for the day of distress”

Habakkuk is using **the day of distress** to refer to the occasion when distress would come. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [for the time of distress]

See: Idiom

Habakkuk 3:16 (#6)

צָרָ֔ה

“distress”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **distress**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [great trouble]

See: Abstract Nouns

Habakkuk 3:17 (#1)

כִּ֣י

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: כִּי”

Here Habakkuk uses the word **Though** to introduce a contrast. Despite the complete failure of crops and livestock described in this verse, Habakkuk will still rejoice in Yahweh (verse 18). Use a connector in your language that indicates a strong contrast between an undesirable situation and an unexpected response. Alternate translation: [Even though]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Habakkuk 3:17 (#2)

כְּחֻשׁ֙ מַעֲשֵׂה־זַ֔יִת

“the olive”

Habakkuk is speaking of **the work of the olive** as if it were a person who could be **deceptive**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the olive tree has failed to produce a crop]

See: Personification

Habakkuk 3:17 (#3)

מַעֲשֵׂה־זַ֔יִת

“the olive”

Habakkuk is using the possessive form to describe **the work** that is done by **the olive** tree, that is, the olives or oil that the olive tree produces. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the crop from the olive tree]

See: Possession

Habakkuk 3:17 (#4)

גְּזֵ֣ר מִמְּכְלָ֔ה צֹ֖אן וְאֵ֣ין בָּקָ֑ר בָּרְפָ֖תִים

“the flock & and {there} are no”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of clauses in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [and we have no domestic animals]

See: Parallelism

Habakkuk 3:17 (#5)

גְּזֵ֣ר מִמְּכְלָ֔ה צֹ֖אן

“the flock”

If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the sheep and goats vanish from their pens]

See: Active or Passive

Habakkuk 3:18 (#1)

וַאֲנִי בַּיהוָה אֶעְלֹזָה

“yet I, I will exult”

Habakkuk is stating the pronoun **I** separately and repeating it, even though the verb translated as **will exult** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize his personal commitment to joy in Yahweh despite the circumstances. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [Yet as for me, I will exult in Yahweh]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Habakkuk 3:18 (#2)

בַּיהוָה אֶעְלֹזָה אָגִילָה בֵּאלֹהֵי יִשְׁעִי

“will exult & I will rejoice”

See how your translation team has decided to represent pairs of clauses in Hebrew poetry that mean basically the same thing. Alternate translation: [I will greatly rejoice in Yahweh, God my Savior]

See: Parallelism

Habakkuk 3:19 (#1)

יְהוִה אֲדֹנָי חֵילִי

“Yahweh the Lord {is} my strength”

Here Habakkuk is speaking of **Yahweh the Lord** as if he were **strength** itself. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh the Lord strengthens me]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 3:19 (#2)

וַיְשֶׂם רַגְלַי כָּאַיָּלוֹת

“my feet”

The point of this comparison is that just as **deer** are able to walk with sure footing on steep and rocky terrain, so God gives Habakkuk the same kind of stability and confidence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and he made my feet as sure-footed as deer’s feet]

See: Simile

Habakkuk 3:19 (#3)

וַיְשֶׂם רַגְלַי כָּאַיָּלוֹת

“my feet”

Habakkuk is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and he made my feet like the feet of the deer]

See: Ellipsis

Habakkuk 3:19 (#4)

וְעַל בָּמוֹתַי יַדְרִכֵנִי

“and on & he makes me tread”

Here Habakkuk is speaking of positions of safety and victory as if they were **high places** on which he could walk. If this image communicates well in your language, please use it. If not, you could express this as a comparison. Alternate translation: [and in my places of safety he enables me to walk securely]

See: Metaphor

Habakkuk 3:19 (#5)

לַמְנַצֵּחַ

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: לַמְנַצֵּחַ”

Here, **the chief musician** refers to a person who directed the singing and playing of music at the temple. This closing line indicates that the prayer in verses 1–19 was intended for use in temple worship. If your readers would not be familiar with this role, you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [For the music director] or [For the worship leader]

See: Translate Unknowns

Habakkuk 3:19 (#6)

בִּנְגִינוֹתָי

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: בִּנְגִינוֹתָי”

Here, **my stringed instruments** refers to stringed musical instruments used in worship. This indicates how the prayer of verses 1–19 was to be accompanied. If your readers would not be familiar with this type of instrument, you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [to be accompanied by my stringed instruments] or [with music from stringed instruments]

See: Translate Unknowns